

**May Day protest**

On May 1, 1917, a massive labor demonstration took place in Petrograd. Every Soviet (workers' council) in Russia was represented at the march. Many carried banners bearing political slogans.

Street fighting

Supporters of Lenin flee the gunfire of Provisional Government forces in Petrograd, July 1917.



“History will not forgive us if we do not **assume power** now.”

LENIN, 1917

BOLSHEVIK Founded by Lenin in 1912, the Bolshevik Party was committed to a workers' (proletarian) revolution and the overthrow of the imperial regime.

1917 he ordered troops into Petrograd to protect the government. Fearing that Kornilov intended to seize power for himself, Kerensky asked the Bolsheviks for assistance, which they duly provided, in the form of a mass of workers, who persuaded the troops to turn around.

The Kornilov affair seriously weakened the Provisional Government, and in October Lenin secretly returned

to Petrograd. He announced to the Bolshevik Party's Central Committee that the time for revolution had arrived, entrusting the military organization of the revolution to Leon Trotsky (see pp.380–81).

October Revolution

On October 25—according to the old Russian (Julian) calendar, November 7 in the modern (Gregorian) one—Trotsky's men executed an almost bloodless coup in Petrograd. Armed squads of pro-Bolshevik revolutionaries occupied key positions such as train stations, banks, post offices, and

telephone exchanges. The battleship *Aurora*, flying the Bolshevik Red Flag from its mast, dropped anchor in then Neva River with its guns trained on the Winter Palace, where Kerensky's government was in session. After the firing of a single blank shell from the ship and two shells from another gun position, the government surrendered.

That night, Lenin issued a powerful address to the Russian people, entitled “To All Soldiers, Workers, and Peasants,” in which he promised to transfer the lands of the aristocracy, the church, and crown to peasant committees and to establish the workers' control over Russia's industries. The people of Russia would at last become their own masters. The Bolsheviks moved quickly to secure supremacy over other political groups, ensuring that soviets took over control across Russia, and ensuring that they alone would form the new government.

Lenin's immediate concern was to make peace with Germany and end an exhausting and costly war. Firmly believing that revolution would soon spread across the capitalist world, he accepted Germany's peace terms, failing to anticipate the furious international reaction against his new Russia that was about to be unleashed.

In the aftermath of the Russian Revolution, the Bolsheviks faced both internal and international opposition. They acted ruthlessly to tighten their grip on power.



THE ROMANOV FAMILY

EXECUTION OF THE ROMANOVS

After his abdication Nicholas II and his family were kept under **house arrest**, moving in the spring of 1918 to Ekaterinburg in the Urals. On July 17, as anti-Bolshevik forces were advancing, Nicholas, his wife, their five children and servants were taken into the cellar of the house and shot. There is no evidence of a direct command from Lenin: the **death sentence** was passed by the local regional Soviet. The family's execution removed one of many threats to the Bolsheviks' rule.



RED ARMY BADGE

CIVIL WAR

In 1918 the anti-Bolshevik **White Army** launched attacks against the new regime. They received military support from many countries including Britain, France, and the US. During the next three years the **Bolshevik Red Army** fought invasions in the Baltic, the Caucasus, Siberia, and Ukraine.

BIRTH OF THE SOVIET UNION

By the end of 1920 the counter-revolutionaries were defeated and absolute Bolshevik military and political power was established. Russia was renamed the **Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR)** or **Soviet Union** in 1922.

NEW ECONOMIC POLICY

During the civil war, the Soviet economy teetered on the **brink of collapse**, and money became virtually worthless. With the urban population and the army close to starvation, the state seized surplus food from peasant farmers without payment. In 1921 Lenin's “**New Economic Policy**” replaced these seizures with a regulated tax and as trade increased, the economy revived.

COMINTERN

Also known as the “Third International,” Comintern was founded to promote **worldwide revolution**. Stalin **378–79** >>

dissolved the association as a gesture of goodwill to the Allies in **World War II** **380–81, 392–405** >>



COMINTERN MEMBERSHIP CARD

RUSSIAN LEADER (1870–1924)**VLADIMIR ILYICH LENIN**

Lenin became politicized after his elder brother was hanged for his part in a plot to kill Czar Alexander III. In 1895 he was exiled to Siberia for revolutionary activities. On his release, Lenin spent several years in Europe, where he studied Marxist theory. His 1902 essay *What is to be done?* argued for a workers' revolution, under the leadership of a strong government. Lenin came to power in the October Revolution, but died less than seven years later. However, his politics provided the inspiration for further Marxist revolutions in many countries.

